

Compact Cities, Nature, Urban Spaces and COVID-19 Pandemic

Introduction

The COVID-19 pandemic has had a significant influence on neighbourhoods and cities around the world, posing new problems. To stop the COVID-19 pandemic from spreading, local and national government administrations declared obligatory lockdowns or sternly worded regulations. This pandemic has directly affected the very beginnings of urban planning and architecture theory and practice (Allam & Jones, 2020).

The COVID-19 epidemic has had devastating socioeconomic effects on cities, resulting in global unemployment records and rising inequality. While communities went into lockdowns to maintain a reasonable level of health, the difficulties associated with the pandemic's progression have necessitated a radical rethinking of the metropolis. '15-minute cities' or 'neighbourhoods' are aspirations that cities all across the world have made public. This objective frequently forms a component of a plan to promote biking and walking in order to lower emissions and create a sustainable and healthy urban design. Demand for active transport has changed significantly as a result of mobility restrictions and social-distance interventions associated with COVID-19.

This essay is themed around compact cities - a '15-minute city' concept, and how nature should be considered an important factor in city planning both politically and geographically. The essay will address the most complex urban planning and design challenge of the COVID-19 pandemic faced by Australia in recent times. 'Our cities have changed as a result of social separation, lockdowns, fears about "community transmission," crowds, and public meetings as the "urban" experiences. New experiences brought about by COVID have surfaced the '15-minute city' concept. Using historical precedents such as the 'Spanish flu' in 1919 and other influenza pandemics in accordance with city planning, this essay will evaluate how to best plan for the future of public spaces while rethinking what is a future city centre, as the economic dynamics have shifted after the pandemic.

Idea and Argument

Almost 70 per cent of the world's people are predicted to live in cities by 2050 (Rogers, 2020). The question that always comes up for discussion is 'What is a City?'. The definition of a city differs from person to person, but one thing that remains constant is the relationship between the built environment of the city and the people living in that area. Urbanism is concerned with the design and function of cities, and their relation to the rural areas and it often refers to how the residents of urban areas interact and engage with the built environment and social structure of their cities. It was discussed by Rogers, that the three urban characteristics are a large population, a high population density and social diversity. Cities are complex entities made up

of socio-spatial elements including organic, material, environmental, cultural, and human-related processes. The design of cities is influenced by multiple factors such as nature, geographical location, topography, economic considerations. Political factors and agendas also indirectly influence city planning. Urban politics involves many connections and becomes an important place where topics like ethnicity, class, gender, and environmental concerns intersect. Sometimes, some of these factors are overlooked by the planners. However, nature is often given the least priority and is overlooked in the planning process, with other factors taking precedence. Urbanization of nature is an inevitable consequence of a city's growth.

Cities are often described as different from the natural world but are also considered an integral part of the ecosystem. The city is an essential component of nature, and nature is closely entwined with urban social structures (Benton-Short, & Rennie Short, 2008). The natural world and human society are meant to be enjoyed together (Swyngedouw et al., 2003). Cities greatly depend on nature for various resources. According to Lewis Mumford, our housing and city planning have suffered because those in charge lacked a comprehensive understanding of the social functions of the city. It is important to consider the impact of urbanization on the environment and society, and incorporating nature into urban areas can help prevent socio-environmental deterioration. The main objective of the urban age is to build cities that are inclusive, sustainable, and productive. Urban areas are the most common type of settlement because they provide large areas, accumulation, and interaction with the economies. But cities may be significantly weakened from the inside due to the overwhelming demand of the population on infrastructure and basic services, which is an immediate concern (Clark, 2003).

Several city planning concepts have been proposed by different urban planners. During the 20th-century urban planning movement, The Garden City by Ebenezer Howard gained prominence. It advocated for the creation of satellite communities surrounding the central city, separated by greenbelts. These Garden Cities would have proportionately sized residential, commercial, and agricultural districts. The initial goal of Howard's idea was to combine the advantages of both the city and the countryside while minimising their respective drawbacks. This started a new movement for the development of new towns in the West. During the 20th century, the design of colonial and post-colonial capitals was greatly influenced by the principles of Garden City.

The concept of a 15-minute city proposed in 2016 is gaining popularity. It draws inspiration from Clarence Perry's neighbourhood unit, as well as historical ideas of proximity and walkability, among other factors. Urbanist Carlos Moreno's 2021 article introduced the 15-minute city concept as a means of ensuring that in urban areas people may complete six key functions within a 15-minute walk or bike ride from their place of residence. These essential functions include living, working, commerce, healthcare, education and entertainment. With this approach, cities can become more efficient, sustainable, and enjoyable places to live. The provision of basic urban amenities near urban centres is necessary, and these services shouldn't discriminate against people based on their socioeconomic level or age (Moreno et al., 2021).

As the cities are evolving and increasing population density, the pressure on the cities to be sustainable is rapidly increasing. The cities lack breathing urban spaces

and city life thus becomes monotonous. To break this cycle cities should have urban open spaces with integration of nature and natural elements in them. Although nature is deeply ingrained in urban social life, its presence is frequently unanticipated and unplanned (Benton-Short, & Rennie Short, 2008). People are social beings. They require fulfilling interpersonal relationships. The interaction and participation of the community within the neighbourhood and the city are largely dependent on the design of urban spaces. This essay will further discuss linkages between the compact 15-minute cities, nature, and urban spaces and the role they have or would have played during the COVID-19 pandemic.

Image and Argument



Image 1: Khude, A. (2023). What is Debate? Image Task C, UPD4301 Critical Debates, Photoshop Image

Cities are home to most of the world's population and are centres of economic growth and innovation. Due to the high concentration of people and activity in cities, these areas are more vulnerable to stressors such as natural and man-made disasters. (Sharifi & Khavarian-Garmsir, 2020).

The World Health Organisation (WHO) declared coronavirus (COVID-19) a worldwide pandemic by the end of March 2020. It is one of the most devastating challenges faced in human history after the Spanish Flu in 1918 during the period of World War I. Both of the pandemics have caused the devastation that lead to rethinking of the city planning. Throughout history, previous pandemics, like the one in 1918, have shown that socioeconomic disparities are exposed and that there have been few efforts after the pandemic to address the concerns of minorities and underprivileged

groups. (Sharifi & Khavarian-Garmsir, 2020). Both of the pandemics have caused the devastation that lead to rethinking of the city planning.

During COVID-19 the whole world was under lockdown. To slow down the spread of COVID-19 and eliminate SARS-CoV-2, governments implemented different public health measures for varying periods. These measures included limiting domestic travel, temporarily shutting down non-essential businesses like hair salons and clothing stores, and enforcing quarantines for international travellers upon their arrival. (Spennemann, 2021). In Australia, the Victorian state government declared a lockdown, restricting residents to just their basic daily functions within a 5-kilometre radius of their residence. Public parks, amenities, playgrounds, places of work, worship, and entertainment were shut down as a result of this lockdown. Only a 5 km radius was available for both shopping and exercise. As a result, individuals started experiencing physical, mental, and social discomfort.

The shops and commercial complexes were all shut down during the lockdown. The large corporations, and supermarkets like Coles, Woolworths, and Aldi fared very well out of COVID as a result, whereas the tiny local businesses suffered a greater loss. In addition to underdeveloped countries, developed countries have also seen the socioeconomic effects of the pandemic. Many small, vulnerable, socioeconomically underprivileged communities were affected by the pandemic. The rapid spread of COVID-19 has brought back the old problem related to social inequality into light. This was because of the inaccessibility to proper healthcare facilities. The current land-use zoning issue is that most of the cities in Victoria just have private housing and commercial complex spaces. This issue surfaced during the lockdown and questioned urban planners and design professionals. The issues related to the vanishing sense of community have been also exposed during the pandemic. Response and recovery efforts may be more difficult as a result of this absence of a sense of community (Sharifi & Khavarian-Garmsir, 2020). It is surprising planning and design experts are not mentioned in discussions on current COVID-19 policies and actions, despite the fact that past pandemics have historically had significant effects on the urban fabric from a social and economic standpoint. (Allam & Jones, 2020).

Post-lockdown social distancing changed the characteristics of social networks in a city. Aversion to crowded public transport pushed more journeys into private road-based transport, lead to the issue of road congestion (Lai et al., 2020).

The COVID-19 pandemic has changed the way we think about cities and what we consider to be the city centre. If cities had been designed with the '15-minute city' concept in mind, the lockdown experience would have been radically different. As shown in Image 1, residents would have had easy access to all the amenities they needed, including housing, employment, shopping, education, entertainment, and healthcare facilities. Everything is accessible within a 5 kilometre of radius their place of residence. This would have reduced limitations on people's regular activities and preserved the sense of community, making the lockdown experience less isolating and more enjoyable. Along with these areas, having access to urban green spaces could have been a method to deal with the detrimental effects on one's physical and mental health caused by this significant live event of COVID-19. (Berdejo-Espinola et al., 2021). If the concept of the '15-minute city' had been implemented, the lockdown experience could have been significantly improved.

People would have had fewer restrictions on their daily activities and a stronger sense of community could have been maintained.

Image 1 clearly highlights the significance of the '15-minute city' and emphasizes the need for easy accessibility to city centres. This approach promotes local businesses and discourages the dominance of big commercial corporations. The importance and discussions about designing compact cities are resurfacing as the pandemic has changed the whole outlook of urban planners and design professionals.

Idea, Image and Argument

The COVID-19 pandemic has already changed the way we socialise, move, and interact with the urban facets of the city. The COVID-19 epidemic brought to light concerns about the advantages of compact urban development. Due to the high levels of face-to-face contact, it was first thought that highly populated and connected places may quickly spread the epidemic. However, reported evidence provided data on the relationship between density and COVID-19 are conflicting and ambiguous (Sharifi & Khavarian-Garmsir, 2020). Drawing lessons from history, non-pharmacological interventions connected to the design and planning of urban built environments have a fundamental role to play in the prevention and management of epidemics and pandemics, in addition to clinical interventions for prevention and treatment (Lai et al., 2020).

Urban green spaces now hold a significant place in society for preserving people's physical and emotional well-being. It is anticipated that future epidemics and perhaps pandemics would occur given the prevalence of related coronaviruses in animal populations (Spennemann, 2021). Transport systems and neighbourhood layouts that allow for human interaction have the power to affect the frequency and severity of infection outbreaks by reducing or escalating infection transmission rates (Lai et al., 2020). The COVID-19 pandemic has presented urban scientists, planners, and designers with a significant opportunity to witness the most extensive natural experiment in various facets of urban activities and people's mobility. The importance of active modes of transport like walking and cycling are being promoted by the councils. Social and community values and definitions have also changed. This has opened up the opportunity for the urban planners to re-consider a city centre and plan cities according to the concept of a '15-minute city'. This COVID-19 pandemic has forced urban planners to analyse and plan the city to a micro level rather than treating every part of the city as a whole.

The relative locations of housing, jobs, and services are shaped by key attributes of the urban built environment, including the type and quality of housing, physical morphology (density, land use heterogeneity, configuration, and design), the quality of infrastructures (public transport, parks, sidewalks, and boulevards), and the level of supported services (recreational facilities, healthcare, food outlets/pubs and restaurants, supermarkets and groceries, places of worship). These attributes also influence population-level mobility, mixing, and social networks (Lai et al., 2020). These key attributes of the urban built environment are resolved in the concept of a '15-minute city'.

Conclusion

COVID-19 has significantly disrupted multiple sectors and has had a profound impact on how people engage with their physical and social surroundings (Spennemann, 2021). As a result of a considerable number of individuals working remotely and restrictions on travel outside local neighbourhoods, the design of housing and the overall quality of neighbourhoods have gained heightened significance in people's daily lives (What Has COVID-19 Revealed about the Liveability of Our Homes and Neighbourhoods? | AHURI, n.d.). Studies conducted before the pandemic have shown that urban green spaces have a positive impact on both the physical and mental health of people. The COVID-19 pandemic has prompted urban planners and design professionals to reconsider the design of cities, with many advocating for compact and community-centred cities.

Designing a '15-minute city' can protect them from pandemics in the future. It is important for urban planners and other professionals to consider various key factors such as socioeconomic conditions, community and public spaces, and the integration of nature into the built environment of cities. By implementing such ideas, we can create a more resilient and sustainable future, where people's regular activities are less restricted, and a greater sense of community is maintained.

The lessons from COVID-19 must be incorporated into urban planning in order to prepare our communities for the future. But the risk of heavy-handed policy responses to COVID-19 runs the danger of producing unexpected results. The scope of this essay was limited to the discussion of the issues related to the COVID-19 pandemic in relation to urban planning in Melbourne, Australia. It was affirmed that the concept of compact cities, a '15-minute city', with the integration of urban public open spaces is crucial for the efficient operation of a city, both during and after a pandemic.

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